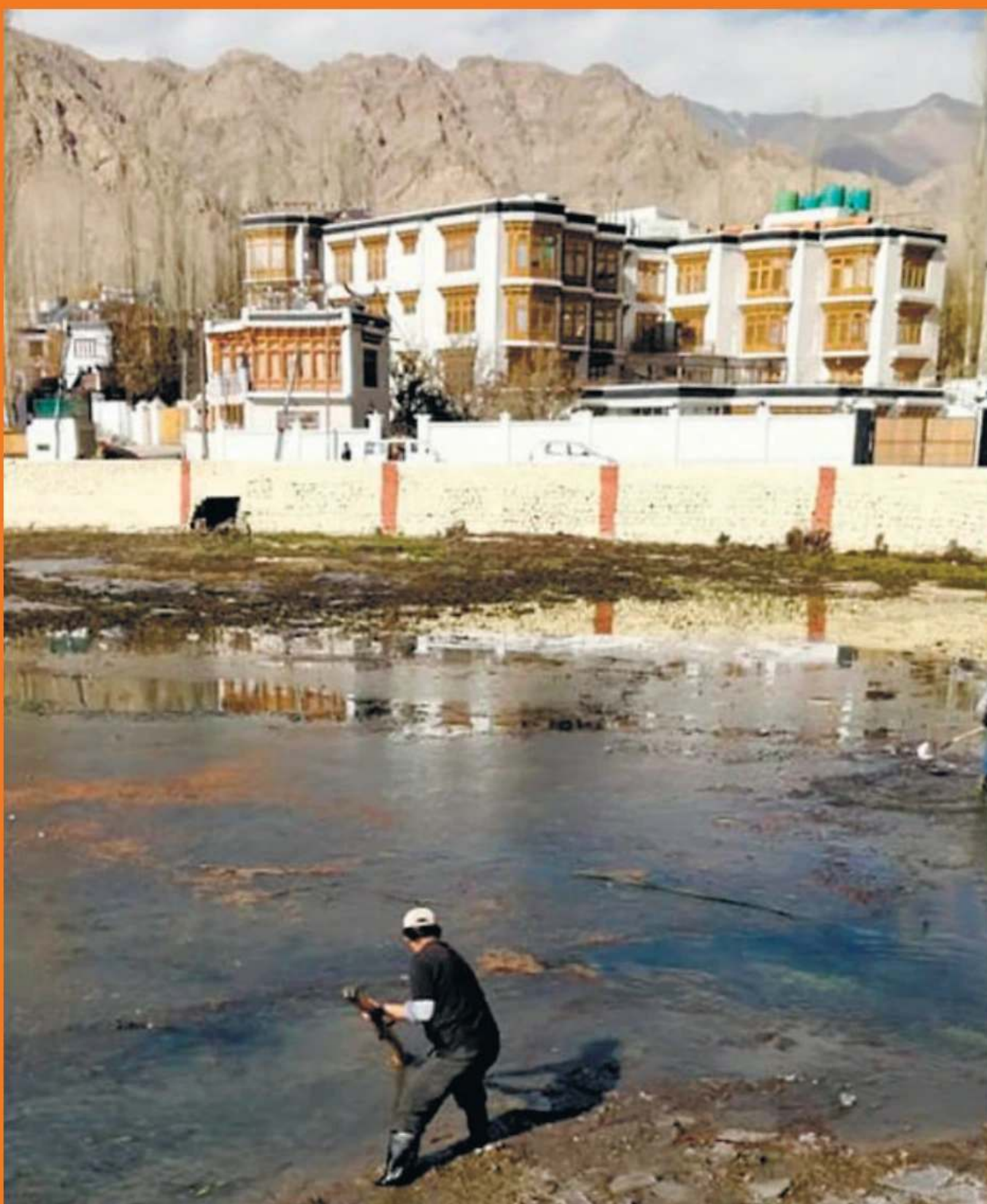




Options galore: Karzoo (above) and many other ponds have served as potential training grounds for ice hockey in Ladakh.

LADAKH WINTER SPORTS CLUB

Department revealed that the Zaskar range is losing thickness at a rate of 117 cm per year, followed by the Ladakh range at 46 cm per year.

A sport that once captivated children around Leh and Ladakh now faces the grim prospect of fewer and fewer opportunities to pass on its traditions to future generations.

"The season has shortened considerably from what I remember as a teenager when I started playing. From lasting up to three-and-a-half months, it has now reduced to just over two months. Things are changing rapidly," says Noor Jahan, a former goalkeeper of the Indian women's ice hockey team, who also hails from Ladakh.

A deeper impact

According to a study by Climate Dialogue, Ladakh's average temperature has risen by 3°C in the last four decades, affecting

agriculture and livestock — both crucial to athletes' nutrition.

"Earlier, we couldn't grow brinjal or capsicum here. Now we can, which is a clear indication of global warming," Namgyal observes. "Previously, we had heavy snowfall and little rainfall. Now, the pattern has reversed, and I fear it will cause problems with the availability of drinking water in the future."

In 2023, Ladakh recorded 58.8

mm of rainfall, its highest in 14 years, with 19.1 mm falling in just two days – July 8 and 9 – against the usual 0.1 mm, a staggering 10,000 per cent increase. The region also registered a maximum temperature of 33.5°C last summer, three degrees higher than the previous year.

"Growing up in the mountains, so close to nature, you notice these changes very clearly. Climate change is very real," Noor adds. "We face

Nerve centre: Ladakh is currently the heartland of Indian ice hockey.

SHASHISHEKHAR KASHYAP

